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PROCEEDINGS OF MINI-PLENARY SESSION OF NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Members of the mini-plenary session met at Committee Room M46 at 10:00.

House Chairperson Mr W Horn took the Chair and requested members to observe a moment of silence for prayer or meditation.

APPROPRIATION BILL

Debate on Vote No 29 - Agriculture:

The MINISTER OF AGRICULTURE: House Chair, hon members, Frank Sinatra once sang: *"Love is lovelier the second time around, Just as wonderful with both feet on the ground"*. Let us see if it goes the same for speeches.

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We meet at a moment where the story of South African agriculture is beginning to change in substance, and not just in sentiment. Over the past year, the sector has demonstrated resilience in the face of global volatility, tightening margins, and structural constraints. Our agricultural exports reached R268,7 billion in the fourth quarter of 2025, reflecting year-on-year growth of approximately 9% with a trade surplus of over R24,6 billion in that quarter alone, as well as close to 950 000 jobs created across the value chain.

Agriculture is not a marginal sector. While primary agriculture contributes 2,8% to GDP, the broader value chain accounts for around 14% of economic activity. That multiplier effect is precisely why agriculture must sit at the centre of our economic strategy, and not at its margins.

But numbers alone do not tell the full story. What matters now is whether that growth is translating into real, tangible benefit for the farmer on the ground. Whether it is deepening value chains, expanding opportunity, and building resilience into a sector that needs to carry far more of the nation's economic future.

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Over the past year, we have spent a huge amount of energy on opening doors that were closed for too long. Our citrus exports to the People's Republic of China and other parts of the world expanded, supported by the successful amendment of coal treatment protocols. I am immensely proud to announce that for the first time, we overtook Spain as the world's largest export of citrus by volume with 2,9 million tons exported in 2025. That's where the ... [Inaudible] ...

Now I want to extend my thanks and acknowledgement to the citrus growth association delivery farm and farmworkers and our citrus. It has done us so proud.

The question therefore before us is not whether we can open markets, we can demonstrate that. It is whether we can ensure that the benefits of that market access flow through the entire value chain, from the packhouse to the smallholder, from the exporter to the emerging farmer seeking to enter that system.

And that is why the Agriculture and Agro-processing Master Plan remains central to our approach. It is not just some abstract framework. It is the mechanism for coordination, and

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for aligning government, industry and labour behind a shared objective. We are beginning to see measurable movement. The share of value produced by black participants in commercial value chains has increased from 11% to 13%, with much of that progress driven by gains in horticulture. While this movement is encouraging, it remains far too uneven across commodities and highlights a broader pattern. Evidence from the National Agricultural Marketing Council, shows that integration is advancing where structured support and coordinated value chain interventions are in place, particularly in a high-value export sector.

We need to be honest about the challenge. The sector remains highly concentrated in key areas, particularly in staple production. Growth that is not inclusive will not be sustainable. As Wandile Sihlobo, the Presidential Envoy for Agriculture and Land Reform, recently noted, our focus cannot be on dividing the existing pie, but on growing it; this is critical for the prosperity and stability of the South African society at large.

This budget is therefore directed at deepening the value chains, not just expanding output. Programme Four, Economic

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Development, Trade and Marketing, receives R924 million to continue driving market access, addressing tariff and non-tariff barriers, and supporting the integration of producers into the higher-value segments of the market.

If we are truly serious about building a more inclusive agricultural economy, then access to finance also remains one of the most important constraints we must address. Over the past year, the Blended Finance Scheme has continued to demonstrate the value of coordinated partnerships between the government, and development finance institutions as well as the private sector. Since its inception, the scheme has approved approximately R9,8 billion in support for the agricultural sector, consisting of both grant and loan funding, benefiting 627 black commercial producers across multiple commodities as well as value chains. Through the Industrial development Corporation, IDC, partnership alone, 42 transactions valued at over R4 billion have been approved, supporting approximately 7 869 jobs, while the Land Bank component has supported over 6 480 jobs through more than 600 approved transactions. We need to do far more to create far better access to cheaper more patient capital for our farmers.

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At the same time, Programme Three, Food Security and Support, remains the largest allocation at R3,2 billion, reflecting the central role of farmer support and extension services in unlocking productivity and inclusion.

We recognise that access to information remains one of the most significant barriers constraints facing farmers, particularly smallholders' farmers. Those who try transition from subsistence agriculture and to commercial agriculture. Too often, our farmers operate without timely, localised information on weather patterns, pest outbreaks, input use, and market opportunities. We are therefore exploring a hybrid model that complements the existing extension system with a digital platform, one that expands reach, enables real-time support from our farmers, and begins to modernise how we deliver services and information to our farmers across the country.

This is not about replacing extension officers. They are irreplaceable. It is about equipping them, and the farmers they serve, with the tools that they require to operate in a modern digitalised agricultural economy.

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We also recognise that no single institution can meet the increasingly complex demands of modern agriculture. That is why we are moving progressively toward a more pluralistic extension model, one that strengthens collaboration between government, commodity organisations, agribusinesses, researchers, NGOs and producers themselves.

Programme Two, which encompasses biosecurity, research and natural resource management, has been allocated R2,5 billion, with a significant portion directed towards strengthening research, diagnostics and export compliance systems. I was outstanding to read fake news yesterday evening that we have only allocated R10 million to biosecurity. Of this amount allocated, approximately R494 million has been spent, with a remaining balance of R1,607 billion earmarked for the continuation and expansion of our vaccination programme for Foot-and-Mouth Disease. This reflects both the scale of the challenge before us and the seriousness with which we are approaching the protection of our national herd and the long-term sustainability of the livestock sector. An amount of R120 million of the Comprehensive Agriculture Support Programme, has also been dedicated to the war against Foot-and-Mouth-Disease a very far cry from R10 million.

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A key part of this shift is the rebuilding of domestic capability. The Agricultural Research Council, which receives the largest share of our entity allocation, is now central to this effort. As we move determinedly towards rebuilding our biosecurity ecosystem in South Africa.

The extra-long staple, ELS, has reached an important milestone with the rollout of vaccines produced through its recently installed mid-scale production system, with more than hundreds of thousands of doses now in production. Further expansion is already underway. An order has been placed for a 1 000-litre vaccine production fermenter, which is expected to produce approximately 960 000 doses per cycle. However, in a short and medium term, we will remain reliant imports of vaccines from my partners biogenesis and Dolvid.

This progress reflects more than increased output. It marks a deliberate expansion of local manufacturing capacity and reinforces our ability to support national disease control efforts from within our own borders.

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But resilience is not only about disease control. It is about preparing for the risks that lie ahead for the agricultural sector. The likelihood of an El Niño event developing in mid-2026 presents a real threat to summer crops, and to food security more broadly. Our response must be grounded in science, supported by early warning systems, and aligned with climate-resilient production practices.

If we are serious about unlocking the full potential of the agricultural sector, we must also confront honestly the structural constraints that continue to hold it back. One of those constraints is the disconnect between production and industrialisation.

This is where the conversation on biofuels now becomes critical. Biofuels are not just simply energy intervention, which can greatly alleviate some of the current input facing the agricultural sector. They represent one of the few policy levers that simultaneously drive rural employment, agro-processing, and industrial development. Even a 2% blending target has the potential to create approximately 25 000 jobs, largely in rural areas.

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But most importantly, for our grain farmers facing this international trade particular maize and wheat on low prices high stockpiles, and constrained export markets, biofuels will introduce a structural demand mechanism that can absorb surplus production and stabilise prices and give our farmers options about how they can direct their products to achieve maximum profitability because profitability is the bedrock of agricultural survival and how we keep our family farmers on their farms but also how we see growth in the sector.

In countries like Brazil, the industry of biofuels has evolved into a market-responsive system, where mills are able to switch between sugar and ethanol production. In India, the government has taken a phased and careful managed approach, while actively managing food security risks through policy controls and pricing mechanisms. And this will be a lifeline for our struggling sugar sector in South Africa and a game changer for provinces like Mpumalanga and KwaZulu-Natal.

The lesson for South Africa is clear. The success of the biofuels industry does not lie in ignoring food security concerns, but rather in managing them intelligently.

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Our state entities are central to delivering on this agenda, and they must be fit-for-purpose. Strong governance, independent boards, and clear accountability are absolutely non-negotiable if these institutions are to fulfil their mandates.

The employment practices and the boards selection processes must focus on fit-for-purpose and ensuring that they are able to meet their mandate.

At the centre the Department of Agriculture itself must avoid the transitional from the start up structure to a fit-for-purpose, one, marks a critical step in our institutional development.

Agriculture has always been a sector of quiet resilience. But in the years ahead, it must become a sector of deliberate growth. Growth that is inclusive, growth that is export-oriented, and growth that translates into, jobs and investment opportunity.

The President has set us a clear target: To increase value-add in the sector by 30% and unlock 300 000 jobs across in the

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value chain. This budget is directed at achieving that objective. Not through rhetoric, but through the steady work of building markets, strengthening institutions, supporting farmers, and deepening value chains.

The work ahead is significant. But the direction is clear. I thank every farmer and farmworker across the length and breadth of South Africa from our small scale all the way to our mega farmers for the contribution that they make every day and not only to food security in our country but into ensuring that they are providing jobs, growing economies and providing lifelines in many of our rural economies that still suffer under dispensation, exclusion and marginalisation.

The Agriculture Department stand ready to pay extra in transforming the agricultural landscape and turning this now into a sector that really delivers on growth and jobs.

I hereby table the Budget Vote for the Department of Agriculture and look forward to the debate. Thank you very much, House Chair.

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The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Before we proceed, visitors in the public gallery, we really appreciate your presence, we welcome you. But in terms of our internal Rules and orders, may you please not participate by way of applause. Please, leave that or other reactions to the members in the Chamber.

Ms D D PULE: Thank you very much hon Minister and Deputy Minister, members of the House, my colleagues, the leadership of the department led by the Directors-General, DG, Ramasodi, and I see represented by Deputy Directors-General, DDGs, here today and the leadership of the entities. Condolences to the DG and the family for the loss of their mother, distinguished guests and fellow South Africans who are watching.

Today we rise as the ANC at a defining moment for agriculture in South Africa and across the globe. We are debating agriculture today not merely as an economic sector, but as the backbone of food sovereignty, rural developmental, job creation and national stability. We do so at a time when the world is gripped by geopolitical instability, climate shocks, rising energy costs and disruptions to global supply chains. These realities compel us to strengthen fiscal responsiveness

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and agricultural resilience in an increasing volatile geopolitical landscape, Minister and Deputy Minister.

The 2026 conflict in the Middle East has once again exposed the vulnerability of global agricultural systems. Fuel prices continue to rise sharply, fertilizer costs remain unstable, and shipping routes have become more expensive and uncertain. For South African farmers, fuel now constitutes nearly 13% of production costs. This is not merely an economic statistic. It is a direct threat to food affordability, farm-style sustainability, and national food security.

This situation demands decisive intervention from government, Minister and Deputy Minister. We must intensify support for mechanised farming, improve access to affordable fuel alternatives, and expand incentives for efficient production technologies.

If we fail to act decisively, rising production costs will inevitably be transferred to consumers, worsening hunger and inequality.

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In this regard, we welcome and acknowledge the allocation of R7,84 billion to the Department of Agriculture as evidence of the ANC's continued commitment to food security despite the tightening fiscal vice facing our country.

However, hon members, fiscal allocation alone is not enough. The true measure of transformation lies in whether resources translate into inclusive growth and genuine economic participation by the majority of the previously disadvantaged and especially women.

This is why the ANC advocates strongly for the full implementation of the Agriculture and Agro-processing Master Plan as the primary social compact for inclusive agricultural growth. The master plan remains one of the most important instruments for uniting government, labour, farmers and agribusiness, financial institutions and communities around a shared developmental vision.

It provides a practical framework for industrialisation, market access, export growth, localisation, employment creation, and farmer inclusion. Most importantly, the master plan must become the vehicle through which black farmers move

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beyond symbolic participation into meaningful ownership, productivity, competitiveness, and scaling.

For too long, transformation in agriculture has focused merely on participation statistics. We can no longer celebrate entry into the sector without ensuring sustainability and growth within the sector, Minister and Deputy Minister. We therefore welcome the shift towards genuine scaling of 370 Black commercial producers through the blended finance scheme managed by the Land Bank. This initiative represents a critical departure from fragmented support models of the past. Through blended finance, emerging Black commercial farmers are now better positioned to access affordable capital, infrastructure support, working finance and technical assistance necessary for expansion and long-term viability.

This can only be possible if the Land Bank Minister, plays its role in supporting these farmers because in the past, we have seen them lagging somewhere. This program must not remain small in scale. It must become a national catalyst for the development of a new generation of black commercial producers who can compete effectively in domestic and international markets.

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But hon members access to finance is inseparable from access to secure land tenure. We therefore call for the urgent implementation of the Land Redistribution Bill and the Expropriation Act to provide secure tenure and collateral opportunities for communal land farmers.

Millions of South Africans residing and farming on communal land continue to face structural exclusion from mainstream agricultural finance because they lack legally recognised tenure systems that can unlock investment opportunities. Without secure tenure, farmers cannot leverage land financing, cannot invest confidently in the infrastructure, and cannot fully participate in the agricultural economy. This reality perpetuates inequality and undermines rural development.

The implementation of progressive land reform legislation must therefore strike a balance between redress, productivity, investment certainty, and food security. Without secure tenure farmers cannot leverage land for financing, cannot invest confidently in infrastructure, and cannot fully participate in the agricultural economy. This reality perpetuates inequality and undermines rural development.

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The implementation of progressive land reform legislation must therefore strike a balance between redress, productivity, investment certainty, and food security. Land reform cannot remain a slogan. It must become an instrument of economic empowerment and agricultural expansion.

The future of agriculture is also inseparable from energy security. South African farmers continue to face unbearable electricity costs. Electricity tariffs have risen by approximately 68% over recent years, placing immense pressure on producers, processing, irrigation systems, storage facilities, and agro-processing operations.

In this regard, we strongly support and champion the Agro Energy Fund valued at R1,2 billion. This intervention is both timely and strategic. Through solar energy systems, biogas installations, and alternative energy solutions, the Agro Energy Fund offers farmers an opportunity to reduce operational costs improve sustainability and shield themselves from the devastating effects of load shedding and escalating tariffs.

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Importantly, this programme must prioritise inclusivity. Smallholder farmers, emerging blood producers, cooperatives, and rural farming enterprises must not be excluded from the energy transition opportunities. The green transition in agriculture must not become another avenue inequality. It must become a pathway towards equitable growth and climate resilience.

Hon members, agriculture remains one of the few sectors capable of simultaneously addressing unemployment, poverty, hunger, industrialisation, and rural underdevelopment. Yet achieving this potential requires more than policy statements. It requires coordination, urgency, implementation capacity, and political will.

Xitsonga:

Hi fanele ku aka ikhonomi ya vurimi leyi tiyeke, leyi kotaka ku tiyisela ku tsekatseka ka tipolitiki ta misava, ku cincacinca ka maxelo, ku katsa na ku kavanyeteka ka timakete.

English:

We must build a resilient agricultural economy capable of withstanding geopolitical shocks, climate vitality, and market

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disruptions, Minister and Deputy Minister. We must ensure that public investment translates into expanded production, job creation, and inclusive ownership. We must empower Black commercial farmers not merely to survive, but to scale and thrive. We must secure tenure in ways that unlock investment and dignity for communal farmers. And we must modernise agriculture through renewable energy and mechanisation to safeguard the future of food production in South Africa.

In conclusion, hon members, agriculture is not simply about crops and livestock. It is about sovereignty, stability, dignity and nation building. If we invest wisely, Minister and Deputy Minister, we implement decisively and transform inclusively, agriculture can become one of the greatest drivers of South Africa's economic renewal. We support the budget, hon House Chairperson.

Xitsonga:

Ndza khensa, Mutshamaxitulu wa Yindlu. Inkomu.

English:

Thank you.

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Mr Z E MTHETHWA: Greetings Chair and greetings to the hon Minister, the Deputy Minister, our fellow hon members, officials and those who are watching us from ... different homes.

Minister, this budget you are tabling looks exactly like ... in the old order regime before 1994. I'm saying this because the agricultural industry has not moved an inch from where it was in the old order.

One of the points is the following. If we were to look at agriculture according to the economic factors of production, one of the factors of production is land. The second one is buildings. The third one is owner's equity. The fourth one is labour.

If you don't have any of these four factors of production as a black person, you are outside the economic circulation of the agricultural sector.

So, let's check. Out of South Africa's population of 62 million, 92% are black. However, this 92% are without the

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land, which is a factor of production. That's the first problem.

Secondly, let's look at buildings. Who owns the buildings wherein production can take place? It is not the 92%. It is the 8%, who are white people.

Let's look at owner's equity, where banks lay out capital funds to finance agriculture. Let's look at who owns the banks in South Africa. It's not blacks. It's whites.

Okay, let's look at labour. We thought that because labour is provided by us as blacks, therefore we would own that labour. No, the opposite is true. Whites also own the labour. It is they who run consultancy firms to deploy labour into every production ... in this country ... in the agricultural sector.

Okay, given that background, it then means the following.

There is no transformation in the sector, because since we claimed land in 1994, the report in terms of returning that land to the 92% that is supposed to be enjoying participating in the agricultural economy, is gathering dust. They're not getting it.

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What does that do? What are the implications of them not getting this land? It means they are outside the agricultural economy.

Let's go on and look at veterinary doctors who are involved in our animal production. There is a group calling itself the alternative South African veterinary council. Do you know what that means? It's white veterinarians who don't want to be part of the mainstream SA Veterinary Council led by Mam'uMnisi.

So, that means we are running agriculture in a parallel way. Let alone that agriculture is already functioning at a commercial farming level, which is whites only.

Then you find our emerging farmers, given the mandate of the Agriculture Department, which excludes land. It means our emerging farmers and communal farmers will be without growth because there is no land to be allocated to them in order for them to grow. So, they are perpetually emerging. And, those who are perpetually emerging are blacks. It is not whites.

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Looking at the percentage of participation of our farmers, it is around 13%. Now, check 13% against 92% in terms of total participation.

Let me look at Amakhosi. There is no history where Amakhosi consumed food that was farmed by white farmers. What happened to the land of Amakhosi? What happened to them being supported by this government for them to be able to ply their trade? We used to farm for our own subsistence economy. We used to barter ... trade. We used to control the entire value chain. Today, we are expected to go to Spar, Woolworths, to get our food. That is a shame.

And we are sitting here. That is the history of the previously disadvantaged, and we are undermining it and we are downplaying it here.

In KwaZulu-Natal, we have 2,8 million hectares of land. The so-called owners of the banks don't want to capitalise it. Why? They say it's unbankable. Okay, let's check. It is only unbankable when a black king is in charge of that land, but once it exchanges hands with a white farmer, now it's capitalised. Why? It's because those who sit in the bank are

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white, so they are able to give to their fellow whites, but they cannot give to a black king so that they are able to farm.

Then we sit with this 92% who sits with these people. We've done the calculation. Out of a population of 62 million, 25 million of the population are sitting permanently ... [Inaudible.] ... This means you have 25 million people who are outside the economy. Agriculture is one of the basic industries wherein they should be working; not just working for a white farmer, but working for themselves, for their own livelihood. But, they have to render their skill.

Let's look at what's happening here in the Western Cape, in the Winelands to be specific. An amount of 400 million was given in an equity share scheme to commercial farmers, so as to allow their workers to be part of the ownership of those farms here in the Winelands.

These white commercial farmers took that money from the state for themselves and they fired all the workers that are equity shareholders by virtue of the equity share scheme. By the way, the scheme was started here in the Western Cape in 1992 by

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Sanlam. The same people who provided this scheme as the way to go are the ones sabotaging it, so that our people are not part of the ownership of the sector.

So, what is happening here? There's a pull and push whereby our people are not expected to be part of this industry. The status quo is being allowed.

We're looking at USA. Last year we said we needed to treat the matter of the USA with kids' gloves because the USA is a big economy. Check what the USA is doing in response to that. They're putting tariffs on our goods and services that we produce here.

Furthermore, they don't stop there. They go and tell our neighbours by force that you will give us your rare minerals. If you don't do that, we'll sabotage your government's service- delivery programme.

So, what are we drawing from this? We are drawing ... we have the arrogance of First World countries that want their own way or the way in the emerging economies, and yet we must come

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here and play as if we are working together. So, until when are we going to do that?

However, let's move on and look at ... Yesterday, I saw ...

IsiZulu:

... Isijingi (pumpkin porridge) ...

English:

... now being served and sold at Woolworths. Pumpkin porridge is Isijingi in IsiZulu. That is our staple indigenous food which I grew up eating.

It was never part of the dinner table and retail stores when I was growing. I only saw yesterday that it is now one of the mainstream foodstuffs that is being sold. But, let us check who supplies that pumpkin which is now at Woolworths. Surely it is not the old ladies. Surely it is not the co-operatives. Surely it is the same commercial farmers.

Why? They have access to land. There is no way our people can sustain the security of supply of pumpkin porridge at Woolworths. They will never allow you ... until you give them

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security of supply, where you need to guarantee that you have access to land. Who's got this land? The same status quo. So, it then means we must come here ... [Inaudible.]

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Thank you, hon Mthethwa.

Mr Z E MTHETHWA: We oppose this budget. Thank you.

Afrikaans:

Mev D VAN DER WALT: Huisvoorsitter, Minister, die departement en kollegas ...

English:

... in an open letter to the agricultural sector published in *Farmer's Weekly* at the end of 2025, Minister John Steenhuisen conveyed his optimistic outlook for 2026. In the letter, the Minister rightfully shared that 2026, "holds immense promise, and together we can turn that promise into progress."

Taking the Minister's remarks into account, it is crucial that the department's 2026-27 budget assists the agricultural sector in navigating ongoing global economic uncertainty, geopolitical shifts, climate pressures and diseases.

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Maintaining the optimistic outlook previously conveyed by the Minister is essential for the success of this sector.

Afrikaans:

Die prestasies van verlede jaar het inderdaad 'n sterk fondasie vir 2026 gelê en dit is belangrik dat ons met die 2026-27 begroting verder daarop kan voortbou.

English:

The South African agricultural sector continues to be a beacon of hope for the South African economy, as it has continuously created more jobs for communities across our country.

Three days ago, on the 12th of May, Statistics SA released their Quarterly Labour Force Survey. Their report showed that the broad unemployment rate for the country is currently at 32,7%. Despite other sectors struggling, the farming sector continues to create jobs and now employs about 960 000 people.

In comparison, there was a 3% increase from the same period a year ago and a 1% increase from the last quarter of the year 2025.

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Collaborating with industry has clearly enhanced new and expanded markets for our produce. Landmark export deals signed by Minister Steenhuisen with China significantly expanded access to South African fruit, including the October 2025 stone fruit protocol and the recent tariff-free export agreement.

The agreements entered into by the Minister as part of the China-Africa framework agreement are subject to a two-year period with zero tariffs for several South African agricultural export products.

Afrikaans:

Baie geluk aan ons sitrusboere, plaasarbeiders en die waardeketting vennote met die week se bekendmaking dat Suid-Afrika vir Spanje onttroon het as die wêreld se nommer een sitrusuitvoerder volgens volume, met 'n rekord getal van 2,9 miljoen ton sitrus wat uitgevoer is.

Ons glo die sitrussektor se Vision 260 doel om 260 miljoen houers van 15kg elk teen die jaar 2032 uit te voer sal behaal kan word en selfs moontlik oortref kan word.

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English:

Concerning foot-and-mouth disease, FMD, it is essential that we continue learning from and benchmarking against countries that have successfully addressed this disease, and that this work be supported.

We commend the Minister's recent visits to Argentina and Brazil to gain insights from their experiences and best practices. Currently, Argentina is FMD-free with vaccination. Due to this controlled status, Argentina is a major beef exporter to international markets. There is a lot we can learn from countries such as this.

With millions of vaccines imported from Biogénesis Bagó in Argentina and Dollvet in Türkiye, there is clear evidence that the department is aggressively obtaining vaccines.

The Minister recently shared that by the end of May, South Africa would have received a total of 15 million vaccines. This amount is sufficient to vaccinate the entire national herd of 14 million cattle once.

Afrikaans:

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Die departement se doelwit is steeds om minstens 80% van die nasionale kudde teen die einde van Desember in te ent. Dit is dus belangrik dat die begroting hierdie doelwit ten volle ondersteun.

Die Wes-Kaap het tot einde April vir vier maande geen nuwe gevalle aangemeld nie. Die doeltreffendheid van provinsiale departemente wat saam met die nasionale regering en plaaslike strukture werk is duidelik en word steeds gedemonstreer in die provinsie se huidige stryd teen 'n nuwe uitbraak.

Deur te verseker dat die nasionale kudde ingeënt en uiteindelik bek-en-klouseervry word sal ook kan verseker dat ons wilddedryf siektevry sal wees.

English:

The Department of Agriculture's achievements in 2025 and the recent successes highlight the advantages of disciplined budget management. With R7,8 billion allocated by the National Treasury for the years 2026-27, the department should maintain effective use of these funds, as it has demonstrated previously.

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Afrikaans:

Ek dank u.

Ms L H ARRIES: Chairperson, the EFF rejects the Budget Vote No 29 on Agriculture. South Africa has faced one of the most acute outbreaks of the foot and mouth disease in recent memory. Despite this, our response to this crisis has been lethargic, uninspired, disjointed, and without a broad vision of containment and vaccination. The foot and mouth disease has caused havoc amongst still emerging and largely black livestock farmers. It has completely destroyed a source of livelihood for many commercial farmers in the former homelands. And yet today, Minister Steenhuisen does not know the true extent of this devastation and there have been no vaccination efforts of any kind in the former homelands.

The little effort made towards vaccination is limited to the constituency and the white farmers who mistreat and kill our people on the farms. Despite the struggles we are facing with foot and mouth disease, the biosecurity subprogramme receives only 0,1 per cent of the department's total budget. This is a dangerous contradiction. Government says biosecurity is a priority but allocation amounts to almost nothing.

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Chair, the EFF is equally concerned by the reckless transfer of billions to provinces and the Land Bank without measurable oversight mechanisms. Almost R2,9 billion is transferred. Yet there are no clear annual targets to check whether these funds reach emerging farmers, rural communities and struggling households. The Blended Finance Scheme continues to receive funding despite repeated complaints from black farmers who cannot access it. What we are seeing is the recycling of public money into bureaucratic structures while small farmers only stay excluded from land markets, infrastructure, and finance.

The department speaks about transformation, yet black producers stay marginal participants in commercial agriculture. There are no concrete targets to increase black ownership, no aggressive programmes for agro-processing and no serious intervention to build townships and rural food economies. We welcome the increased allocation to animal production and health, but this alone is insufficient. Vaccine shortages persist. Onderstepoort Biological Projects continues to suffer from instability, delays, and leadership failures. Freeze drier installations are delayed yet again, while farmers wait for vaccines and outbreaks spread across

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countries. The EFF has long warned that the collapse of state capacity in veterinary science and vaccine production would become a national disaster. Today, this warning has become reality.

Chairperson, another critical concern is the abuse of measurable targets to co-operative development, despite the R686 million being given to this programme. How can Parliament exercise oversight over money that has no clear outcome attached to it? This is not budgeting for development. This is budgeting without accountability.

The EFF believes agriculture must be radically transformed through state support, agro-processing industry, expanded access to land for black farmers, public investment in irrigation, storage and transport infrastructure. Through community food production programmes, strengthened veterinary and biosecurity capacity and guaranteed market access for small producers through schools, hospitals and state institutions.

Food production cannot remain in the hands of a privileged minority, while the majority remain consumers of expensive

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imported goods. Chairperson, South Africa is the land, the climate, the people and the productive capacity to end hunger. What is missing is political will. The budget does not rise to the scale of the crisis facing our people. It lacks urgency, measurable transformation, and decisive intervention.

The EFF therefore rejects the complacency reflected in this budget and calls for a radical restructuring of agriculture policy in favour of the poor, black farmers, farm workers and rural communities in South Africa. Thank you.

Inkosi R N CEBEKHULU: Ngibonge Sihlalo, Mhlonishwa Ngqongqoshe nethimba lakho, uSihlalo wekomidi, amalunga ahloniphekileyo ale Ndlu, kuyiqiniso elingephikwe ukuthi uMnyango weZolimo uyisisekelo esikhulu sokuba kwande amathuba amaningi omsebenzi emiphakathini yethu, kanjalo futhi nokondla nokuphakela isizwe nokukhiqiza okuya emazweni angaphandle ukuze abalimi bakwazi ukusimama nabo emsebenzini wezokukhiqiza ezolimo.

English:

The IFP recognises this budget vote and welcomes the department's decision to increase support for smallholder farmers.

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IsiZulu:

Kunjalo uhulumeni ubuyise umhlaba ebantwini kodwa uMnyango awukwazanga ukubaxhasa abantu. Njengamanje abantu bayakha kulomhlaba obukhiqiza ukusiza isizwe ngamathuba emisebenzi. Inselelo ke le uMnyango okufanele uyibhekisise.

English:

The IFP has always encouraged traditional farming as the way to financially empower local communities. We must recognise that the subsistence farmers are a valuable part of our society. They stimulate economic growth and provide rural communities with food. For this reason, the IFP welcomes the Department's decision to increase funding to the Land Bank programme.

IsiZulu:

Inqaba nje ukuthi uma abantu betsheleka imali lapho, kufunwa inzalo enkulu ebacindezelayo abantu ukuthi bangakwazi ukuya phambili bagcine sebephucwe lowo mhlaba.

English:

The resources will help support smallholder farmers that are the lifeblood of our rural communities. We must encourage that

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subsistence farmers remain included in the future budget plans. However, we note with concern that funding for the food security and support programme has decreased over the past three years.

All households have the right to be food-secure, and cutting the programme's budget will only hinder this. We are also concerned about South Africa's reliance on important vaccines for diseases that threaten our livestock.

IsiZulu:

Kuyiqiniso Mhlonishwa, uMnyango ube nesakhiwo esihle ebesisebenza u-OBP ukukhiqiza imijovo kulashwe imfuyo yethu. Kwenzakaleni ngoba lo Mnyango ubukhona yonke leminyaka? Namhlanje sekufuneka siyothenga ngaphandle imijovo yokujova imfuyo yethu. Ngabe indlela yokuphatha eqondile ebiquhutshwa lapha noma bekwenzakala ini? Umbuzo lowo okufanele sizibuze wona.

English:

The foot and mouth epidemic presents a significant issue for our beef, dairy, and pork industry. Although the country has increased its local vaccine supply, we are still not producing

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at full capacity. The R1,6 billion is still needed to build a sustainable foot and mouth vaccine facility.

IsiZulu:

Siyadinga ukukhuthaza ukukhiqiza imijovo efanelekile ezweni lethu ukuze singanciki emazweni angaphandle.

English:

The IFP believes that South Africa must prioritise local solutions to our agricultural issues. We urge the department to funnel more resources into the development of local vaccines to solve this urgent issue. We must also be aware that the foot and mouth disease does not just affect commercial farmers. Subsistence farmers deserve the same attention as their commercial counterparts and must be included in our solutions. The IFP supports this budget vote and stands for the agricultural system that protects food security while empowering both rural and commercial farmers.

IsiZulu:

Yiqiniso elingephikwe Mhlonishwa ukuthi abantu bakithi badinga ukusizwa. Eminyakeni eminingi eyadlula uMnyango wawukhiphe ogandaganda ukuyosiza ukulima ezindaweni zethu. Labo

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gandaganda kuze kube namuhla abaziwa ukuthi bashonaphi, basiza bani, kuphi. Okufanele uMnyango nakho ukuqikelele ngoba abantu bakithi abanawo amandla nezimali zokuqasha ogandaganda ukuba babalimele. Kuyafuneka abantu basizwe, balekelelwe ngokuba kubekhona ogandaganda bakahulumeni abasiza umphakathi ukuwulimela ukuze umphakathi ukwazi ukuzondla ngoba abantu abavilaphi ukusebenza ngezikhwepha zabo, ukwazi ukuzondla nokuziphilisa. Inqobo nje, uma belekelwa bakwazi ukulima, ngale kwalokho uMnyango siyawuseka kakhulu. Ngiyabonga.

Mr E HENDRICKS: Hon Speaker, hon Minister, Deputy Minister, chair of the portfolio, hon members in the department, on behalf of the PA, I rise to debate Vote 29, Agriculture, a Vote that speaks directly to food security, rural development, and economic justice. Yet despite decades of promises, previously disadvantaged farmers continue to face systematic neglect. That makes it seem as though the system is designed for them to fail.

Land reform beneficiaries are often handed land without necessary support, without access to finance, training, and infrastructure. These farmers cannot compete.

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Vote 29 must ensure that land reform is not symbolic but practical, backed by real investment in skill and resources. Emerging farmers struggle with access to market. Established commercial farmers dominate supply chains, while smallholders are left behind.

Vote 29 must create fair market access, strengthen cooperatives, and ensure that the government procurement prioritises previously disadvantaged farmers. The lack of extension services is crippling, Minister. Farmers are left without technical guidance, mechanisation support, or modern farming techniques.

The neglect perpetuates inequality and undermines food security. Agriculture is the backbone of our economy, but it cannot thrive when previously disadvantaged farmers are set up to fail.

Vote 29 must deliver target support, fair access, and sustainable funding to ensure that these farmers succeed, not just to survive.

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Let us commit to an agriculture system that empowers the marginalised, strengthens food security, and build a truly inclusive economy.

We also want to stand here, Chair, and like the hon Minister or Member of Parliament of the DA and congratulate our own. You know, I looked at her when she was on the podium, Chair, and she was so proud in saying the citrus borer.

We also want to say congratulations to our own black brothers and our own coloureds brothers and Indian brothers, also excelling in agriculture, Member of Parliament. But we congratulate, because that is how we are. No, no, no, no, no, I did not say I want to debate. You see. So ...

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Order, hon members. Hon member, please continue.

Mr E HENDRICKS: Thanks, Chair for pro ... So, Chair, we support this budget, not because we are happy, but because we know our people depend on ...

Afrikaans:

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... die bietjie wat hulle gaan kry van hierdie Budget
[begroting] af.

English:

I thank you.

Afrikaans:

Dr W J BOSHOFF: Agb Voorsitter, alle protokol nagekom. Baie van wat ons vandag gehoor het sal ek eintlik graag op wil antwoord of te minste op reageer in die debat oor Grondhervorming en Landelike Ontwikkeling. So kom ons bly by vandag se onderwerp en ons onthou dat die woord boer met 'n klein letter eintlik 'n beroepsbenaming is wat sê iemand wat sy lewe uit die verbou van gewasse en/of vee maak. Goed, genoeg van die taalles.

As ons na verlede jaar se begrotingsdebat kyk, onthou ek dit verskriklik goed. Ek was baie emosioneel daardie dag omdat ek gesê het dat die bek-en-klouseer, BKS, ramp wat op daardie stadium aan die ontvou was, 'n volkome voorkombare ramp was. Ek het gedog 'n mens was op die punt waar die ding omkeer. Ek het vir geen oomblik gedink dat met die volgende debat, die

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volgende jaar se begroting, ons nog steeds oor BKS gaan praat nie.

Om die waarheid te sê, op 1 Mei was ek by 'n boeredag in Kroonstad waar toonaangewende boere bymekaar was ... deur een van die mega boere van Suid-Afrika gereël ... waar hy toe in sy inleiding sê dat in November toe hy hierdie ding gereël het, het hy nogal gewonder of dit nog op 1 Mei relevant gaan wees. Hy het eintlik gedink dit sou so 'n bietjie mosterd na die maal wees, onwetend dat dit die ergste ooit gaan wees. Dit is 'n reuse, reuse probleem.

Ek is bevrees dat ons kundiges in Suid-Afrika wat regtig baie van die hele onderwerp weet en wat 'n mens miskien kon raadpleeg voor Argentinië en Brasilië, alhoewel daar geen fout is om internasionale raad in te win nie, sê dat Desember as 'n maatstaf vir die eerste inenting beteken dat hierdie probleem nooit opgelos gaan word nie. Dit gaan herbesmetting en herbesmetting veroorsaak. Dit gaan terugkom. Ons gaan nie BKS-vrye status kry nie.

Die Suid-Afrikaanse kudde moet binne agt weke ingeënt word.

Dan moet die opvolg ook weer binne 'n bestek van agt weke

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plaasvind. Dit is nie moontlik nie. Dit is nie moontlik met die bronne wat op die oomblik toegeken word nie.

Ek het nou na die begroting gaan kyk ... so jammer dat 'n mens net vier minute het om te praat. In 2022-23, het die afdeling vir inspeksie en kwarantyn dienste R872 miljoen gekry. Toe val dit na R491 in 2023-24. Toe skiet dit op in die vorige begrotingsjaar na R766 en vanjaar af na R514. Dit is 'n R250 miljoen daling vir inspeksie en kwarantyn. 'n Mens sou dink dat dit moes opgaan. Ons is in 'n krisis wat voortduur.

As ons na die gedeelte wat animal production and health [diereproduksie en gesondheid] genoem word kyk, dan het dit wel van R255 miljoen na R357 miljoen gestyg. Dit is R100 miljoen van die verlies by inspeksie en kwarantyn wat darem by hierdie afdeling opgemaak word.

Die Onderstepoort Biologiese Produkte wat die kern van hierdie hele veldtog behoort te gewees het, het 'n begroting van zero [nul]. Nou, ek weet dit is 'n staatsonderneming maar dit is 'n staatsonderneming in 'n krisis.

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Die Landbounavorsingsraad, LNR, wat wel as die vlagskip in hierdie probleem aangebied word, het 'n toename van R9 miljoen in sy begroting. 'n Bedrag van R9 miljoen kan 'n amptenaar sommer so in 'n agtermiddag se tyd wegdra.

Ons sit met a reuse probleem. Ons hoor hoe die saak hanteer word. Ons sien selfs in die begrotingsdokument waar al die mandate gegee word, is die Wet op Dieregesondheid per ongeluk uitgelaat. Die lyk nie asof ons 'n departement het wat regtig lus het om die probleem op te los nie. Ek dank u.

Mr R A P TROLLIP: Chairperson, ActionSA will be supporting this budget because of the importance of agriculture despite every inclination not to do so. Our disinclination is based on the paucity of plans and lack of measurable targets throughout the Annual Performance Plan, APP, also by the fact that the budget allocation is not aligned to the strategic objectives linked to the National Development Plan and the Medium-Term Budget Policy Statement, MTBPS.

IsiXhosa:

Kulapho kufele khona ithole.

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English:

This mismanagement is compounded by the lack of commitment, competency, capacity, and compliance in the department, specifically in Programmes Two and Three. The two top strategic priorities of driving inclusive growth and job creation, reducing poverty, and tackling high cost of living are not being achieved due to the underperformance of these programmes.

Regarding increased production, the sad reality is that the only sector that shows meaningful sustainable growth and resilience is the commercial sector, whose success has little or nothing to do with the Department of Agriculture. They are on their own and have long ago realised that to expect anything from this department is to expect disappointment.

As for increased food, nutrition, and security, one only has to consider our unparalleled urbanisation rate due to pervasive poverty in rural areas to know that this is nowhere near being achieved.

The primary objective of increasing the share of black producers' production and achieving transformation in the

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sector is sadly defined by failure. I base this assessment not on my own extensive experience, but on our firsthand oversight experiences as a committee. We have observed widespread failure by the Land Bank, the acquisition of marginal farms at premium prices with no audits to ensure that what we have paid for is what we have got.

We have seen beneficiaries of transformation being set up to fail without any effective access to production technology, extension services, animal health, technician support, and the late approval of budget and financial support applications through the Blended Finance Scheme.

We have witnessed farmer production support units that are that in name only, that make no difference to the increased production of black farmers. At Necham Macadamia Nut Farm, where hundreds of millions of rands have been spent, the project is lying in ruins.

The black citrus growers in Nkonkobe and Ngqushwa are failing without title deeds. Some of greenfield projects stalled midway after spending millions of rands with no future plans or funding. Mr. Mphahla cannot pack his citrus crop at

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Ripplemead Packhouse because the state-built facility without proper consideration of maintenance, management, and future sustainability. He can no longer afford to pay the VAT, the electricity, the security, and the salaries of the workers because the other farmers do not pack their fruit there. And the million-rand packhouse is now effectively redundant. The response from the department was find another packhouse to pack your fruit.

The nearest options are 180 kilometers away, and finding space halfway through the citrus season is almost impossible. So, another brilliant black farmer is set to fail. The department has developed a tin ear to the plight of aspirant commercial farmers.

Speaking of failure, I cannot describe it better than a message sent by a DA Member of Parliament, on our committee WhatsApp group about the mismanagement of the foot and mouth disease outbreak. He identifies lack of urgency of provincial agricultural departments. He says in Limpopo vaccinations are taking place without any traceability or reporting, that MECs and officials are totally ignorant about this and cannot answer, that in Gauteng they sit with 300 000 doses unused for

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weeks on end with no reallocation, that in the Free State there is no movement control.

The Minister expects livestock owners to accept this or volunteer for the more stringent and onerous Section 10 regimen. This is why the state-controlled disease remains out of control, and I venture that it is in fact the state and this department that are threatening our biosecurity and not livestock owners. [Time expired.]

The DEPUTY MINISTER OF AGRICULTURE: Good morning to the Members of Parliament, the leadership in the form of chairpersons, Minister and the Chair who guides us this morning.

My task will also include talking to this platform as it is organised for that with our people ...

IsiXhosa:

... abantwana begazi ...

English:

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... out there and all organised people in rural areas. It will be bad thinking if we think we are, as we sit here, the only people who must talk about our successes, failures and challenges in the service delivery without those people. It is very, very important to be a country. Once we are one country, we would also want to acknowledge our bad past, however, move forward to seek to redress what happened to those who were left behind, as our President does not approve of others being left behind. All of us should be working together in order to achieve for all of us.

IsiXhosa:

Ndiyafuna ke ukuba sonke sikwazi ukufika kwesa sithebe. Ukuba usapho luyaxhamla phaya, kufuneka sonke sikwazi nathi ukufikelela kwesa sithebe ngokulinganayo. Ndibhekisa kuwe ke Bawo uMthethwa. Ndiyayiva ingxaki oyibekayo kodwa ndiyacela kubantwana begazi ukuba basondele kwesi sithebe. Kaloku asikwazi ukuba silungiselele umntu ngamnye, abantu mabeze ngobuninzi babo ukuze sibeNguMzantsi Afrika omnye nomanyeneyo.

Ndiyafuna ukuphawula kwezi nyewe zibekwe nguMphathiswa wesebe nabo bonke abaye bathetha emva kwakhe.

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English:

There is a big problem. The problem is that we attend conferences all over the world to build our economy and livelihoods in our own country, but when we make recommendations, when we report, we hardly refer to issues, like we were actually leading as the Department of Agriculture, Land Reform and Rural Development in various platforms, your task teams of agriculture by the global world. However, when we give account, we fail to say whether that was helpful or not.

With reference to previous budgets, I know we do this in the platform with our chairpersons in portfolio committees, we talk about our strategy and our plans to achieve that strategy that we place in our portfolio committees. However, it is not common that when we come here, we are able to account for what we had achieved, so that what we plan going forward is clearly understood by those who are leaders of the community, leaders of the people out there, as well as us being able to evaluate how we progress to what we said. A lot is about that.

I think the chairpersons and the Whippery should increase our time. It is not important for me to come here for five

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minutes, and yet I'm accounting to the people of South Africa and putting forward our plans. A one-sided plan will always get opponents. If you want to go quickly, you need to walk alone. If you want to go a long way, sustaining what you want to do, you need to work together. It is my appeal that our offices, I'm referring to the Whippery in particular and the chairpersons, should be able to work together, understand each other, hand in hand, in order to achieve, other than going different ways while parallel, hoping to meet at the end. Parallel lines will never, never meet.

Talking about the rural communities, we must all remember that our rural communities were not defined as in one understanding or theory. Rural communities were talking to farmers in their farms. They were not talking about indigent traditional communities under traditional leadership. That was another world in South Africa. Therefore, bringing it back will require a process.

Now the haves continue to be recognised and allowed to continue because they have the headstart. On the other side ... this analysis is not about hatred, it's an honest expression that while we give out our budget to everybody, hon

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members and the leadership of the House, Chair, it is indeed a difficult situation.

If I had 0%, you also give me 5%. But the ones who must sustain what they have already acquired over the years, they must sustain and, therefore, you must fund the sustainability because they are all South Africans and we use democracy. What we have, hon members, what you gave to us, we are in a position to spend. Hon Trollip, you know what I'm talking about. You know what is happening in those areas that you referred to ... before the dog comes and eats my time. Dogs are always accused of eating time. I don't know why they don't say, get out, you're wasting our time.

IsiXhosa:

Kuthiwa ixesha lixhatshwe yinja. Mazikhutshelwe phandle kuba ndiyabona ukuba isiqingatha sexesha lam sele simke nezinja. Le nto sayifundiswa nguTat'uMandela.

English:

Tata Mandela said, if you are free, you ought to learn from the people and build on what they have already done. It is difficult to bring new ways of doing things all the time. We

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are also very, very tired of praising other countries, having visited them. Why are they also not learning from what we had before? Because there was indigenous knowledge, there was agriculture in this country.

IsiXhosa:

Thina sikhule sisitya amasi, intloya siyinika iihagu.

English:

Yes, we had everything. We were never, never like everyone, every child, every old woman of my age continues to say ...

IsiXhosa:

... thina sihluphekile ...

English:

... no, no, no. I think we must bring back our pride. As Africans, we can influence other rural communities in other countries if we stand on what we know. Indigenous chickens, I agree with hon Mthethwa the young leader here from the Mthethwa to say ...

IsiXhosa:

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... yinkosi le.

English:

He is leading his grandfather's people and wants to sit here and work hard for the improvement of where he comes from. This should happen, but please remind us ...

IsiXhosa:

... amayeza wethu, imihlonyane yethu, amacimamlilo ethu.

[Kwaphela ixesha.]

English:

Thank you.

Dr N P NKABANE: Hon House Chairperson, hon Minister and hon Deputy Minister and fellow South Africans, today as we consider the Budget Vote on agriculture, we must speak with clarity and urgency that agriculture is not a stand-alone sector, it is the backbone of rural economies, food security and inclusive growth. This sector begets the raw material, sub fuel South Africa's largest manufacturing sector, turning low value farm outputs into high value marketable exportable goods while multiplying jobs and economic activities.

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The agriculture sector in South Africa contributes approximately 2,8% to 3% to our gross domestic product, GDP, while the broader agricultural value-chain including agroprocessing contributes 14%.

Hon members, therefore, this sector is a vital economic engine that needs to be expanded as well as supported. We cannot the separate local government from the sector as we all know that many of our farmers in rural communities are being strangled by failing local government infrastructure, roads and bridges that collapse after rains, water regulation system that no longer deliver and markets that cannot move produce efficiently. This is not just an agricultural problem; it is a local government failure that we have a responsibility to fix together.

As you know that as the Government of National Unity, GNU, led by the ANC, we declared this year as the year of decisive action to fix local government. We cannot revitalise rural infrastructure without demanding accountability at local government level. There is a need to focus on holding the institutional framework and infrastructure essential for a

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thriving farming economy which hold potential to countrywide job creation.

Studies have shown that there is roughly 1,8 million hectares of land that is used far below its natural potential in three provinces, the Limpopo, KwaZulu-Natal and the Eastern Cape. In this regard our local municipalities need to direct much of their energy and resources to infrastructure maintenance and investment in line with the guidelines from National Treasury by allocating 8% of its Budget towards infrastructure initiatives that will ensure proper roads and prevent collapse of rural roads to make it impossible for farmers to get inputs in or harvest out.

In terms of fresh produce markets, the Competition Commission's Fresh Produce Market Enquiry affirm that our fresh produce market is crucial to food security, food and health and safety local economic development and access to market by small and emerging farmers. This is a platform where farmers bring their produce to be sold usually but not excessively in large volumes to wholesalers, retailers as well as spaza shops.

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As our reflection of the structure of the economy, 84% of market share is concentrated in four markets which is Tshwane, Johannesburg, Cape Town and Durban of which tat is the area the Minister and his team should look at.

According to the Competition Commission, the volumes of fresh produce being sold at the fresh produce market have been steadily declining over the years. This is largely attributed to the lack of unkept and investment of the local municipalities which are the custodians of these markets.

The mostly dilapidated infrastructure at different municipal fresh produce markets across the country poses a challenge to producers, agents as well as buyers.

This is why the Minister should pay attention to. Central to these challenges, the poor infrastructure as municipalities do not reinvest its revenue derived from commissions.

There is a further lack of access by Small, Micro and Medium Enterprises, SMMEs, as well as historically disadvantaged farmers which points to barriers to entry participation as well as expansion. This is the matter that the Department of

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Agriculture needs to monitor closely and the committee to consistently oversight.

It is critical for municipalities to ring-fence profits earned from this fresh produce markets they own and operate to fund capital expenditure and where feasible increase budget allocation over and above the revenue generated by these markets.

A special dispensation must be created by these markets to set targets to increase annual saves of SMMEs and historically disadvantaged farmers and should at least increase by 10% annually. It is important that we integrate agriculture support and fix local government to enhance local economic development. As the ANC we support this Budget Vote. Thank you.

Mr W M THRING: Hon House Chairperson, the ACDP under-scores the role of agriculture as central to food security, rural development and economic growth. Yet while the department outlines commitments to farmer support, biosecurity and market access the current allocation of some R7,8 billion reflects a

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concerning decline and fall short of addressing the structural constraints facing the sector.

The ACDP welcomes the increase in employment in the agricultural sector and the great strides that have been made in the citrus exports market as indicated by the Minister.

However, a primary concern of the ACDP is the insufficient support for smallholder and emerging farmers. Despite policy commitments to inclusivity, access to finance extension services and reliable markets remain uneven.

Many rural farmers still lack the infrastructure and technical support needed to scale production limiting agriculture's potential to reduce poverty and unemployment. However, equally pressing is the state of biosecurity and disease management.

The ACDP was scathing in its criticism of the Minister's handling of the foot and mouth disease outbreak as it exposed serious gaps in surveillance and response systems.

Delays at Onderstepoort Biological Products and weak border controls, further compound the risk to both food supply and

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export markets. Proposals such as a Co-ordinated National Vaccination Programme with greater private sector veterinary involvement must be urgently considered.

The ACDP bemoans the infrastructure deficits which continue to undermine productivity, inadequate irrigation storage and transport logistics, contribute to postharvest losses and constrain market access. At the same time the variability of weather patterns is intensifying these challenges. While weather resilient agricultural interventions remain underfunded and fragmented.

Governance challenges in this department, however, persist including 147 critical vacancies within the department, to weak co-ordination across entities and limited monitoring and evaluation mechanisms. These shortcomings reduce the overall impact of public spending and delay implementation.

To make this budget work, the ACDP assets and calls for the expanding of targeted support to smallholder farmers, investing decisively in biosecurity systems and prioritising critical rural infrastructure.

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Additionally, resilient adaptable agriculture must be scaled up and institutional capacity improved through filling vacancies and enhancing co-ordination. As kingdom builders, the ACDP assets that without credible oversight ... control, South Africa cannot secure food sovereignty. No farmers, no food! Thank you, hon House Chairperson. [Time expired.]

Xitsonga:

Ttn S M GANA: Mutshamaxitulu wa Yindlu ...

English:

... let us start by wishing Orlando Pirates well for the game tomorrow where they will be lifting the Betway Premiership championship.

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Relevance, hon member, relevance.

Mr S M GANA: Hon members and hon Minister, it is time for the people to eat. A nation that produces enough food yet allows millions to sleep hungry cannot call itself successful. South Africa is producing enough food to feed everyone in this country, yet hunger is deepening in our communities.

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South African maize farmers are projected to harvest a record 16 million tons of maize this season far more than the 12 million tons we consume. It is also worth pointing that we waste 10 million tons of edible food yet tonight close to 11 million South Africans will go to bed hungry. It is time for people to eat.

In Bishop Lavis in Cape Town, a single mother of three has resorted to shoplifting simply so that her children can survive. Among the shoplifted items in our country is baby formula. Imagine that hon members. Mothers stealing food for babies in a country overflowing with agricultural potential. What makes this even more painful is that this very department once issued a guide on how to spot shoplifters.

Hon Minister, we should not only identify desperate people. We should be eliminating the desperation itself. The true measure of success of this department cannot be exports carnage and the trade, agreements, it must be measured by one thing above all else the reduction in the number of South Africans who go to bed hungry.

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Yes, we recognise the progress that is made. South Africa has become the largest exporter of citrus products in the world. More international markets are opening to South African farmers and agricultural producers. These are important achievements. However, those successes will remain hollow if they do not translate into South Africans eating, economic growth expanding and more South Africans finding work.

Support for established and emerging farmers and smallholder farmers must always be linked to a national mission to getting South Africans to eat. To that end the National Food and Nutrition Security Plan must be finalised without delay. Agriculture must fight hunger, reduce poverty and restore dignity.

We also want to recognise the work that is being done by MEC Vuyiswa Ramokgopa in Gauteng to combat hunger and manage the foot and mouth disease in the province. That work deserves support and replication across the country. We have a responsibility in our lifetime to end hunger and poverty.

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This department must ensure that South Africans do not only produce food, but they get to eat it too. Up the Bucs! [Time expired.]

Xitsonga:

Ndza khensa swinene, Mutshamaxitulu wa Yindlu.

Mr C F B SMIT: Hon House Chair, before I start

Afrikaans:

... wil ek net vir die agb Boshoff sê dat hy groete aan die vorige Adjunkminister van Landbou onder President Jacob Zuma moet stuur asseblief. Ja, ek kan nogal goed onthou.

Agb Voorsitter, ek dink jy verwar die Botswana entstof se tydlyn met die entstowwe van die Landbounavorsingsraad, LNR, Dollvet en Biogénesis Bagó wat 'n baie langer periode is. So, ek dink jy moet dalk ook 'n bietjie daaroor oplees.

English:

Hon Trollip, thank you that you have raised the things that I've raised on the portfolio committee. But what you failed to say is that 90% of the things that you raised is either the

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exclusive responsibility of provincial government or other departments that are not under the control of the hon Minister, John Steenhuisen. It is something that we need to address. If we compare the Western Cape's performance with other provinces, there's a clear difference and even you agreed to that.

Hon Pule, I thank you for the fact that we are now, as the DA and ANC, on the same page in terms of the fact that ownership of land in communal areas is a very big issue. If we do not have secure land ownership for collateral, agriculture in that industry won't grow.

Hon House Chair, today we debate a Budget Vote that is not merely about numbers on the balance sheet, but about the resilience, productivity and future of one of South Africa's most strategic sectors - agriculture. Agriculture remains one of the few sectors in our economy that consistently creates opportunities, earns foreign exchange, supports rural livelihoods and expands exports into global markets.

Last year alone, primary agriculture contributed nearly R500 billion rand to the South African gross domestic product,

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GDP, a record high for the sector. Agricultural exports reach an extraordinary R266 billion generated in trade surplus of R124,6 billion. This means that agriculture earns South Africa approximately R340 million in foreign exchange every single day. In a growing economy where growth is desperately needed, agriculture continues to stand tall as the beacon of productivity and economic contribution.

These achievements did not happen by accident. They are the results of hard work by farmers, farm workers, organised agriculture, exporters and, importantly, the decisive leadership from the department under the stewardship of Minister John Steenhuisen. Minister Steenhuisen has brought renewed energy, urgency and reform-minded leadership to the Department of Agriculture, DoA. Under his leadership, South Africa has strengthened its international market expansion exports and deepened trade relations that directly benefit our producers and exporters.

One of the most significant breakthroughs has been the very recent implementation of the China-Africa Framework Agreement on Economic Partnership for Shared Prosperity which came into effect on 1 May. Through this agreement, most South African

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agricultural exports, including fruit, nuts, wine and meat, now enjoy zero tariffs in China's markets for the next two years. This is a major victory for South African agriculture. Previously, our wine faced tariffs of between 14 and 20%, while macadamia nuts faced tariffs of 12%. These reductions dramatically improve the competitiveness of South African products in one of the world's largest consumer markets and open new opportunities for growth, investment and employment.

South Africa's citrus industry provides another excellent example of the sector's global success. The Citrus Growers' Association of Southern Africa reported that South Africa exported 2,9 million tons of citrus in 2025, making our country the largest citrus exporter in the world by volume, ahead of Spain; olé. This achievement reflects the strength of our export-oriented agricultural model, our farmers' commitment to quality and South Africa's compliance with international plant health and sustainable standards. It demonstrates that South African agriculture can compete with the very best in the world when supported by effective governance and expanded market access.

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This Budget Vote supports a sector that feeds our people, powers our exports, sustains rural communities and contributes meaningfully to economic growth. We, therefore, commend Minister Steenhuisen, his leadership reform ... [Time expired.] ... We encourage him to continue. Thank you.

IsiZulu:

Nk S W DAVIDS: Igama lamakhosikazi ...

English:

Hon Chairperson, Minister, Deputy Minister, fellow members and the public at large, I rise on behalf of the ANC to welcome President Ramaphosa's decisive action in declaring foot-and-mouth disease, FMD, a national disaster on 13 February 2026.

This classification is a necessary and bold step, recognising that the FMD outbreak threatens our livestock sector, food security, rural livelihoods and export markets. As the President said, South Africa will be mobilising all necessary capabilities in the state to tackle this crisis. We commend the swift response. It marks a shift towards a modern biosecurity defence, treating animal disease control as a matter of national security.

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The devastation of the FMD export, bans, trade restrictions and ruined herds have reminded us how quickly a disease can disrupt our economy and our livelihoods. No part of our agricultural sector is immune. As hon Steenhuisen, our Minister noted, FMD has long cast a shadow over our livestock sector and is damaging to our economy. By declaring a national disaster, government can now streamline resources, fast-track vaccines and co-ordinate between agriculture, trade, police and disaster management. This integrated approach underlines that biosecurity is indeed a national security imperative. Our food sovereignty and export competitiveness depend on it.

Crucially, South Africa is not fighting the battle alone. We are strengthening South Africa's co-operation in agriculture. During recent high-level visits to Latin America, South Africa signed a Memorandum of Intent with Brazil and developed an action plan that will accelerate our FMD eradication efforts. Brazil was recently declared FMD-free without vaccination and offers a successful roadmap that we can adopt.

A South Africa-Brazil Biosecurity Corridor is on the table. Joint early warning systems and harmonised risk assessment will turn biosecurity from a trade barrier into a bridge for

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growth. The South African strategic alliance brings international science and best practices to bear on our farms. For example, later this month, South African animal health experts will work side by side with Brazilian counterparts to share surveillance methods and disease tracing.

Domestically, we are empowering farmers in the war against FMD. Last month, the government published the Section 10 Routine Vaccination Scheme for FMD in the Animal Diseases Act in the *Government Gazette*. The voluntary fast-track programme allows commercial farmers to lead vaccination efforts at once, rather than waiting for the broader state rollout. Under this scheme, a true public-private participation, a partnership of farmers supply vaccines and hire authorised veterinarians while the state oversees standards and traceability.

Importantly, every vaccinated animal is tracked with ear tags and digital records, assuring safe trade and continuity of the business. This balances the private sector with government oversight. Owners protect their own herds now, yet still under a co-ordinated national strategy. This is what I wanted to say to hon Trollip, that the commercial farmers are co-ordinated by the DoA.

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Today, as we debate the Agricultural Vote, let us recognise that these measures, the National Disaster Declaration, international alliances and the Section 10 Routine Vaccination Scheme, supported by evidence, fit neatly with our target plans for transformation and rural development.

The ANC will continue to work with the Ministry of Agriculture, international partners and all farmers, large and small, to ensure vaccines reach every farm and that our response stays strong. We applaud the President, Minister and leadership, and call on colleagues across committees, trades, industries and international relations to support ... [Time expired.]. The ANC supports Vote 29.

The MINISTER OF AGRICULTURE: House Chair, thank you very much to all of those who participated in the debate. I think it's been mostly constructive and certainly, somewhat insightful.

I think I want to start where the hon Nkabane left off, because probably one of the key elements that came out of today's debate is that point, and it's something we really are going to have to focus on. Because there are areas that impact on agriculture that are outside the executive mandate. And I

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cannot agree with you more, hon Nkabane, about the impact that the state of local government infrastructure is having on constraining agriculture, particularly in rural communities, and it is something that we need to get on top of.

Having returned from three days at NAMPO, this is clearly one of the big issues being raised with us by farmers, both commercial and small-scale, who are struggling to get their goods to market, who are struggling to be able to get their business working, because of the failure of municipal infrastructure. And we certainly welcome the interventions of Minister Godongwana around ringfencing of electricity and water income to ... for direct reinvestment in that infrastructure. You can't farm without water, you can't get your goods to market with potholed roads. And it is something that we need to raise and thank you very much for highlighting that very important aspect.

Let me just also say that it's important, hon Cebekhulu, to note that South Africa lost its ability to be able to produce vaccines in around 2006 ... and I'll get to who was responsible and where the blame for that lies on a bit later when I respond to the hon Boshoff.

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But let me just say this, that we have invested, now, within the Agricultural Research Council, ARC, and we'll continue to invest, which is why they got the biggest chunk of our money towards entities this year and to redeveloping local production.

We had 12 900 doses already come off, and at the end of this month the ARC will be rolling out hundreds of thousands of multivalent vaccines ... [Inaudible.] ... It is not enough, however, for local production to meet our demands, which is why we had to go and secure vaccines from other countries.

Now, what have we done? Well, we've broken the vaccine monopoly in South Africa. For almost 20 years South Africa has imported exclusively from Botswana. We are now importing much more aggressive vaccines from Argentina and Turkey. And as I've said, we will import vaccines from any manufacturer in the world who is able to match the field strains that we've lodged with ... [Inaudible.] ... and I encourage anybody, local or international, who is able to get these vaccines and produce them to come forward.

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I would also say that there are other reasons of going to Argentina, not only to get advice, but also to secure supply. We are not the only country facing foot-and-mouth, FMD, outbreaks. Botswana itself is under huge outbreak, China has a massive outbreak of foot-and-mouth disease virus serotype SAT1, Greece is under huge outbreak of SAT1, the whole of the Middle East is suffering under the yoke of FMD. It's not something that is unique to South Africa.

My worry was that our import strategy would be compromised if there was vaccine competition.

So, part of the trip to Argentina was to secure at least 5 million a month of vaccines from Argentina. Since 15 February this year up to the end of this month we would have imported 15 million vaccines into South Africa. That's enough to vaccinate the entire national herd once. But of course, our goal is to vaccinate them twice. The goal is not eight weeks, it's six months. Both the Turkish vaccine and the Argentinian vaccine have a period of six months before booster shot has to be applied. And it is our goal to ensure that we hit that 80% mark by the end of the year.

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History has no empty pages, and we do need to look back about where things fell apart. One of those is the constraint legislative environment that we sit in, with legislation that should have been amended long ago. And Animal Health Act is one of those.

But I went back in the history channels to see where this legislative amendment should have been made, and I found out here that under Tina Joemat-Pieterse the leader of FF Plus, Pieter Mulder, was tasked with, from their press conference:

He will lead a task team made up over among others, ministerial advisors, the Chairpersons of the parliamentary committees and others, to review all Acts before 1984, but including existing laws.

Perhaps if today we were sitting with an updated Animal Health Act, we would not be in the crisis that we are. Onderstepoort Biological Products, OBP, wouldn't have fallen through the cracks had ... and its worst decline was during that period.

As for the hon Trollip, it's impossible, I think he's pathologically incapable of giving credit where it's due. If

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he honestly believes that commercial farmers are able to have their successes without the work done by the department, he's delusional. This department will not be sidetracked by misery merchants.

Hon Arries ... [Inaudible.] ... but your leader goes around shouting *kill the farmer, kill the boer* ... [Time expired.]

Debate concluded.

The mini-plenary session rose at 11:56.